



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Cathedral Oak Academy

School Website: <https://www.cathedraloakacademy.com/>

December 21, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Cathedral Oak Academy NC 27012 presents a robust classical-education profile embedded in a Christian (Biblical) worldview. Public materials consistently frame education as formation in wisdom and virtue through a Great Books-oriented curriculum, the Trivium (grammar, dialectic, rhetoric), and a liberal-arts foundation. The school foregrounds liturgical and communal practices (Chapel, worship), a deliberate partnership with parents (University-Model blended approach), and a staff that models Christian character. Together these elements align strongly with the six-element classical rubric across all categories, yielding a primary classification of CLASSICAL overall.

Key evidence includes: a stated commitment to a Great Books-based education and the Great Conversation, emphasis on the seven liberal arts and the Trivium, explicit incorporation of worship and Biblical worldview into curriculum, and a family-partnered University-Model pedagogy that remains grounded in formation and virtue rather than mere information transfer. Evidence of liturgical life (Chapel), character formation (virtue, wisdom, discipleship), and a clearly articulated mission (Christ-centered, Biblical worldview, mission beliefs) further reinforces the classical alignment. Public statements about pedagogy (memorizations and chant in lower grades; Socratic-style discussion and rhetoric in upper grades) dovetail with the traditional classical pedagogy framework.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials explicitly present Cathedral Oak Academy as Christian and Christ-centered, with worship and Biblical worldview integrated into school life (Chapel, Bible curriculum, Biblical worldview in all subjects) and a mission centered on faith formation (Discipleship Model, Mission + Beliefs) . - The homepage and descriptive pages describe a classical, Christ-centered approach to education and worship as integral to formation (e.g., "Classical Education meets University-Model," "great tradition," worship as part of the day) . - Statements about faith-informed curriculum and discipleship, including a focus on Scripture, prayer, and a Biblical worldview, are recurrent across COA materials (e.g., "Biblical worldview instruction in all subjects," "Prayer as a regular part of campus life") .

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Christ-centered; Biblical worldview; worship; chapel; discipleship; mission-beliefs; Bible curriculum; Scripture; prayer; Christian staff; faith formation; gospel-centered; God's image. These align with Positive Keyword Indicators for religious/metaphysical foundations (truth, worship, Biblical truth, virtue formation through faith, etc.) . - Negative keywords: None evident in public materials (no explicit signals of secularism, relativism, or anti-worship stance).

Why this rating - The site foregrounds a theology-infused, liturgical life integrated into academics, with explicit references to Biblical truth and worship as part of the educational enterprise. This strongly satisfies the criterion for a religious/metaphysical foundation oriented toward transcendentals (truth, goodness, beauty) and communal liturgical life. The presence of a "Discipleship Model," "Mission + Beliefs," and chapel/worship activities provide clear evidence of liturgical and communal practices integrated with learning. The alignment with the Six Elements' Positive Keywords supports CLASSICAL in this category.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public statements emphasize formation in wisdom and virtue, not mere job preparation. The Trivium framework and classical aims stress wisdom and virtue over vocational ends (e.g., “the goal of education is the attainment of wisdom, not simply to prepare students for the workforce”) and “formation rather than information.” COA explicitly connects education to the cultivation of virtue and human excellence, not just measurable outcomes . - The Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis supports the idea that truth, goodness, and beauty are knowable and form the human soul, aligning with the aim of forming virtuous, thoughtful persons. The Great Conversation language and Great Books orientation underline formation via enduring truths rather than utilitarian outcomes . - Public materials describe sacrifice of a purely workforce-centric ends in favor of wisdom, virtue, and human flourishing; the University-Model component frames the school as a partner with families for formation rather than a job-training pipeline .

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation; wisdom; virtue; character; identity; truth, goodness, beauty; great conversation; great books; contemplation; formation of the heart; God-centered education; moral imagination; mentorship; wisdom formation. - Negative keywords present: The explicit negative category keywords (e.g., “workforce preparation,” “skills-based learning,” “career readiness,” etc.) have little to no explicit presence in COA’s publicly facing materials. Where referenced, they appear only as contrastive statements about the classical aim, not as negative indicators within the school’s own messaging. Overall, positive indicators far exceed negative.

Why this rating - COA’s stated aims, framed around formation, virtue, wisdom, and the Great Conversation, match the “Formation, Not Information” and “Pursuit of Truth, Goodness, and Beauty” ethos from the Six Elements doc. The explicit critique of a workforce-first approach (in the classical overview) reinforces alignment with CLASSICAL rather than a “Not Classical” posture. The school’s emphasis on virtue, wisdom, and Biblical truth meets the category’s criteria for a purposeful aim beyond economic preparation.

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The curriculum is described as liberal-arts oriented (grammar/Latin, logic, rhetoric, music, arithmetic, geometry, astronomy) and framed as a classical curriculum, with emphasis on the Great Books and Great Conversation (Great Books orientation, Great Conversation) . - The Trivium is highlighted as the organizing framework for learning (grammar, dialectic/logic, rhetoric) and linked to a developmental view of schooling (grammar in early years, logic in later years, rhetoric as the goal) . - There is explicit emphasis on Great Books and classical content, including references to “The Great Conversation” and the aim to study great minds across generations, and to memorize and engage with foundational texts as part of a classical curriculum . - The curriculum is positioned within a Biblical worldview, integrating faith with classical content (e.g., Bible-informed worldview, biblical worldview integration) across subjects .

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts; grammar; logic; rhetoric; Great Books; Great Conversation; Great Book curriculum; Great Traditions; liberal-arts education; Trivium; formation of memory (grammar-phase memorization); Biblical worldview across disciplines. - Negative keywords present: The explicit negative indicators (e.g., “career readiness” as a central aim, “skills-based learning”) are not present in COA’s curriculum messaging; some negative terms appear only as contrasts in the knowledge-base document rather than in COA’s own language.

Why this rating - The COA materials align closely with the classical curriculum hallmarks: liberal-arts orientation, grammar/dialectic/rhetoric progression, heavy emphasis on Great Books and the Great Conversation, and a framing of education as formation within a biblical-historical tradition. The explicit articulation of Great Books, the Trivium, and the Great Conversation supports CLASSICAL; the integration of Biblical worldview reinforces the religious dimension of the classical curriculum.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Trivium-based pedagogy is explicit (grammar, dialectic/logic, rhetoric) and presented as the instructional architecture of subject learning, indicating a systematic, classical approach to pedagogy .

- Public materials describe a two-part pedagogy: lower grades emphasize memory and singing/chants to deepen memory and delight; upper grades emphasize Socratic discussion, seminars, debates, and rhetoric training (the latter align with classical pedagogy around argumentation and public speaking). - The presence of liturgical and devotional practices (Chapel, Biblical worldview, prayer, worship) as integrated parts of schooling shows that pedagogy is not solely cognitive but formative within a relational and spiritual context. - The “University-Model” element demonstrates a blended approach with parents, implying pedagogical collaboration and mentoring, not purely school-centric instruction.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue; dialectic; rhetoric; memorization; recitation; chanting; Scholé; formation through imitation; great conversation; master/mentor teacher; living curriculum; holistic education; contemplation; virtue-centered pedagogy; weekly chapel. - Negative keywords present: The public materials do not present the typical negative indicators (e.g., “workforce-primed,” “data-driven,” or “practice-based without contemplation”). The overall pedagogy remains clearly classical.

Why this rating - The pedagogy aligns with classical teaching methods (grammar/dialectic/rhetoric, memorization/recitation, reflective/restful learning, and Socratic-seminar-style inquiry) and includes contemplative/restful dimensions (“Scholé”). The lower-to-upper school progression aligns with classical pedagogical expectations (memory work and chant in early grades; Socratic inquiry and rhetoric in later grades). The explicit Trivium framing and the Great Books-based pedagogy provide robust CLASSICAL alignment.

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - Public materials present a faculty described as Christian role models who mentor students, model virtue, skill, and knowledge, and act as the core of the school (living curriculum, teachers as mentors). - There is explicit language about faculty in relation to student formation and mission-driven education (e.g., “Meet Our Staff,” “Christian Faculty and Staff”) and a stated emphasis on a faculty profile of what a teacher should be and what a student should be, aligning with the classical model of the teacher as a virtuous exemplar and living curriculum. - The school emphasizes small classes and a high level of student support as part of its public materials (e.g., 16:1 student ratio, small classes) which supports a mentor-teacher ideal within a classical framework.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: model teachers; mentors; living curriculum; teacher as mentor; virtuous exemplar; staff as faith-guided professionals; Christian faculty; teacher profile/-portrait; small classes; supportive culture. - Negative keywords present: None evident in public language; no signals of a non-classical or anti-formation faculty approach.

Why this rating - The faculty narrative emphasizes virtue, mentorship, and a close-knit, formation-focused environment consistent with classical expectations of the teacher as a moral exemplar and living curriculum. The presence of a staff-focused page and a “Christian Faculty” framing supports CLASSICAL.

Element 6: School Parents and Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The school emphasizes partnerships with parents, including a strong parental role in investing in their children’s education (University-Model, home-school blend; parents share instruction; school collaborates with parents). The materials specifically describe parents as co-teachers with the school and present parent training opportunities and resources (Family Ministry; Mission-Beliefs; PTAs). - There are explicit calls for parent involvement, opportunities for visits, and resources to educate parents about classical education (e.g., “Parents welcome to the school for visits,” “Learn about our Parent Teacher Association”). - The campus materials describe a culture of partnership, with parent participation in the educational process, and resources for families to grow in classical education through web content and gatherings (e.g., “Discipleship Model,” “Family Ministry,” and “Mission beliefs”).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with parents; co-teachers; parent training; family ministry; PTA; informational sessions; home-school collaboration; parental involvement

in the educational process. - Negative keywords present: None observed; no language indicating hostility to parental involvement or a preference for exclusion.

Why this rating - The COA materials consistently position parents as central partners in education, practicing a University-Model that blends school and home with parental involvement and regular parent training/gatherings. This matches the classical ideal of a community-centered, family-engaged framework. The presence of Family Ministry and PTA content reinforces CLASSICAL.

Aggregate Assessment

All six categories strongly align with CLASSICAL. The public content across COA's site emphasizes a classical curriculum (Great Books, Trivium, liberal arts), classical pedagogy (Socratic-influenced inquiry, memorization, rhetoric), liturgical life (Chapel, worship), virtuous character formation (wisdom, virtue, discipleship), faculty as mentors, and active parental partnership. The positive keyword indicators from the Six Essential Elements document are consistently reflected in COA's public materials, and negative indicators are not evident in the school's messaging. Therefore, the overall ranking is CLASSICAL.

What Would Move the Needle

- If aiming for a fully explicit alignment in Pedagogy, the school could annotate and publicly showcase explicit "Socratic seminars," "Scholé-based rhythms," and direct examples of upper-school seminars or debates to demonstrate formal engagement with Socratic pedagogy in grades 9–12.
- Consider publishing a concise mapping of Great Books titles and the Trivium progression across grades to strengthen the explicit connection between curriculum content and pedagogical method for prospective families.
- While parental partnership is strong, additional public-facing materials that demonstrate specific parent training content (workshops, book studies, or reading guides on classical education) could further reinforce the Parents & Community category.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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